



THE COMPLETE GUIDE

RCRA Hazardous Drug Waste Guide

P-listed, U-listed, and characteristic drugs — Subpart P, the sewer ban, and how to identify and destroy each.

DEA-REGISTERED

EPA-COMPLIANT

NO CONTRACT

CERTIFICATE OF DESTRUCTION

Compliance, made simple.

Hazardous drugs, identified & destroyed.

A subset of the drugs on your shelf are federally hazardous waste the moment you discard them — and EPA's RCRA rules, tightened by Subpart P, decide how they must be managed. Misclassify one into ordinary drug waste and you have a violation; over-classify and you overpay for incineration. This guide explains the P-list, U-list, and characteristic wastes, what Subpart P changed for healthcare, the absolute sewer ban, and how to destroy hazardous drug waste compliantly.

The good news

You don't have to memorize the regulations. A good hazardous-drug list mapped to your formulary — plus one clearly labeled container — handles the day-to-day, and we help you build it.

AT A GLANCE

Who regulates what.

Agency	What it covers in your practice
EPA	RCRA Subpart P (40 CFR 266) — the management standard for hazardous waste pharmaceuticals at healthcare facilities; the sewer ban.
EPA	P-list & U-list (40 CFR 261.33) and characteristic wastes (D-codes, 40 CFR 261.21–.24).
DOT	Packaging and shipping papers for hazardous waste in transit.
State	Authorized states may run RCRA with stricter requirements and their own lists.

THE STREAMS

Every stream, in depth.

Below is each regulated stream your practice produces — what belongs in it, what does not, the rule behind it, how to dispose of it, and a tip to stay clean.

WASTE STREAM 01

P-listed (acutely hazardous) drugs

The strictest category — acutely hazardous, with low quantity thresholds and even the empty container regulated.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Warfarin >0.3%
- Nicotine (patches, gum, e-liquid)
- Epinephrine base
- Physostigmine, arsenic trioxide

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Epinephrine salts in most formulations (commonly excluded)
- Non-listed, non-characteristic drugs

THE RULE · EPA — P-listed wastes are acutely hazardous; residue and contaminated packaging are regulated unless the container is RCRA-empty (triple-rinsed / de minimis).

DISPOSE WITH · An RCRA-hazardous kit destroyed by permitted high-temperature incineration.

Tip

Nicotine products are P-listed — the nicotine gum and patches in your sample drawer are hazardous waste when discarded.

WASTE STREAM 02

U-listed & characteristic drugs

Toxic and characteristic wastes — the largest slice of hazardous drug waste.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- U-listed (many chemo agents, e.g. cyclophosphamide, mercury compounds)
- Ignitable (D001) — many alcohol-based liquids
- Toxic (D-codes) — e.g. certain preservatives, chromium, selenium

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Non-hazardous pharmaceutical waste
- Trace chemo (RCRA-empty) — its own yellow stream

THE RULE · EPA — U-listed and characteristic drugs are hazardous waste and must be identified, segregated, and destroyed as such.

DISPOSE WITH · RCRA-hazardous kit — same incineration path, documented.

Tip

An ignitable characteristic (D001) catches many alcohol-based and aerosol products people assume are ordinary waste.

WASTE STREAM 03

Subpart P & the sewer ban

The 2019 rule that reshaped how healthcare manages hazardous drug waste.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- A Subpart P management program
- Trained staff & labeled containers
- A hazardous-drug list mapped to your formulary

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Any hazardous waste pharmaceutical down a drain — a hard prohibition
- Counting these toward your generator status (they're excluded under Subpart P)

THE RULE · EPA RCRA Subpart P — healthcare facilities manage hazardous waste pharmaceuticals under a dedicated standard, and sewerage is expressly prohibited.

DISPOSE WITH · A Subpart P-aligned program with permitted destruction and full documentation.

Tip

Under Subpart P, your hazardous-waste-pharmaceutical volumes no longer count toward your monthly generator category — but the sewer ban is absolute.

YOUR CHECKLIST

Your RCRA hazardous drug waste checklist.

- ☐ A hazardous-drug list mapped to your actual formulary
- ☐ Point-of-generation containers labeled for hazardous drug waste
- ☐ P-listed residue and containers handled correctly (RCRA-empty rule)
- ☐ Zero hazardous waste pharmaceuticals to any drain or sewer
- ☐ A Subpart P management approach documented and trained
- ☐ Permitted high-temperature incineration for destruction
- ☐ A Certificate of Destruction and manifests retained

QUESTIONS ABOUT RCRA HAZARDOUS DRUG WASTE

RCRA hazardous drug waste FAQ.

What makes a drug RCRA-hazardous?

It appears on EPA's P-list or U-list, or it exhibits a hazardous characteristic — ignitable, corrosive, reactive, or toxic. Examples include warfarin above 0.3%, nicotine, epinephrine base, and many chemotherapy agents.

What did Subpart P change?

Subpart P (2019) created a dedicated management standard for hazardous waste pharmaceuticals at healthcare facilities, excluded those volumes from your generator-status count, and made the ban on sewerage them explicit and absolute.

Can I ever pour hazardous drug waste down the drain?

No. Sewering hazardous waste pharmaceuticals is prohibited under Subpart P. This is one of the clearest, hardest lines in the rule.

Why is nicotine gum considered hazardous?

Nicotine is a P-listed (acutely hazardous) waste. Discarded nicotine products — patches, gum, e-liquids — are hazardous waste and, as a P-listed material, even the residue and packaging can be regulated.

How is RCRA-hazardous drug waste destroyed?

By a permitted hazardous-waste facility using high-temperature incineration, with manifests and a Certificate of Destruction documenting the chain from your site to destruction.

THE EASY WAY

Handle it with mail-back.

We help you build a hazardous-drug list mapped to your formulary, set up labeled point-of-generation containers, and destroy the waste by permitted incineration under a Subpart P-aligned program — with the manifests and Certificate of Destruction handled for you.

QUICK REFERENCE · WHICH KIT FOR WHICH STREAM

Waste stream	The right path
P-listed (warfarin, nicotine)	RCRA-hazardous kit + empty-container rule
U-listed & characteristic	RCRA-hazardous kit
Trace chemo residue	Trace-chemo (yellow) kit
Non-hazardous drugs	Pharmaceutical waste kit

Prefer pickup, or higher volume?

Hospital or health-system scale? We run Subpart P programs with formulary mapping, staff training, and scheduled hazardous-waste service — ask for a quote.



WHY FACILITIES CHOOSE EASY RX CYCLE

- No contract, no minimums — buy as you need
- Flat-rate pricing — no fuel or hidden surcharges
- One vendor for every stream you generate
- DEA-registered, EPA- & OSHA-aligned destruction
- A Certificate of Destruction on every single order

Ready to simplify your hazardous drug waste?

Shop mail-back kits with prices, or get a custom quote for pickup and higher volume. No contract, cancel anytime.

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